

We show you how to set up your speakers the easy way without breaking your head

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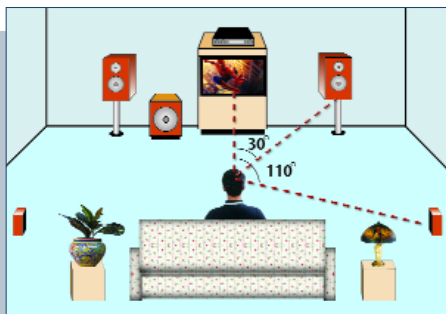
After having read the *Digit* May 2005 speaker comparison test, you must be eager to get your hands on a good set of speakers. Irrespective of what you desire, it is imperative that you install the speakers right. Why? Because even if you get the best set of speakers, and play a song or a film on your PC, it won't sound right if the speakers are not placed properly. Read on, and we will help you place your speakers right.

The Surroundings

The acoustics of the room in which you intend to keep the speakers are important. Even if you get high-end speakers, if the acoustics of the room are not up to the mark, your investment is likely to suffer.

Curtains, carpets, wood and/or metal furniture, all ultimately add to the room's acoustics. So, before you actually get down to screwing the satellites to the wall, check thoroughly at different angles. Of course, not all of us are audiophiles or movie freaks, but a slight exercise in installing the speakers will go a long way in getting a good aural experience.

One aspect is the angles at which you set the speakers. Depending on the dimensions of



An ideal placement of speakers in a room

your room, you should try and stay close to the defined angles. This should be taken as a rule of thumb for users with a 5.1 setup.

Connect Right

Once the new speakers arrive, the first thing you must do is connect them properly to the sound card. Most new motherboards have support for 5.1 speakers, and connecting them to the integrated sound card can be done in a jiffy. This is easy if the cables are colour-coded. However, if they are not, you will need some time to get the configuration right.



A. Colour-coded integrated audio jacks on the back panel of the PC

First, let's take a look at the back panel connectors of the PC. You will see three distinct colour-coded audio jacks—green, blue and pink. The audio jacks have two roles.

In the general onfiguration, a green jack is meant to be the audio line-out, perfect to connect a stereo or a 2.1 set of speakers (most 2.1 speakers don't come with a separate subwoofer connector). The blue audio jack acts as the line-in, and is used to connect devices such as a walkman to the PC for recording from the walkman.

The pink one serves as a microphone jack. This is the general configuration (image A). While the placement of audio jacks may differ amongst motherboards, their colours essentially denote the same functions as mentioned above.

Remember to switch off the PC first, and then connect the speaker wires. You may invariably disturb or unplug any other cable when you are fiddling on the back panel of a powered on computer. If the power cord gets unplugged, you could end up losing a lot of data.

The speakers we used for this workshop had colour-coded audio connectors at both ends which let us easily plug in the cables to the audio jacks on the back panel of the connector.

For a 5.1 setup on an integrated sound card, here's what you should do:



B. Inserting the front speakers connectors to the back panel of PC



C. Inserting rear speakers connectors

The green or front channel speakers go into the green jack (image B). The rear speaker connectors go into the line-in or the blue jack on the back panel of the computer (image C). Finally, the subwoofer connector goes into the microphone or the pink jack on the back panel of the computer (image D).

The final assembly of speaker cables on the back panel of the computer is shown in image E.



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